

Module 2: Fostering Physical and Mental Growth



Background

Child development can be defined as the process by which a child changes over time. It covers the whole period from conception to an individual becoming a fully functioning adult. It is a journey from total dependence to full independence.

This section discusses the developmental changes of each stage, as well as provides tips on healthy eating, proper nutrition, hygiene, and social issues that affect children as they age. It covers how parents can communicate effectively with their children, especially by modelling appropriate behavior. The sections on early childhood, pre-adolescence, and adolescence will aid parents in understanding their children during each of these stages.

Areas of Child Development

There are some basic areas of child development. At each stage of development, the child learns in several areas at the same time. There are five areas of human development:

Physical Development. Changes occur in size, shape, and physical maturity of the body, including physical abilities and coordination.

Intellectual Development. This covers the learning and use of language; the ability to reason; and to logically solve problems of daily routine.

Social Development. This includes development of social skills to interact with the environment in a socially acceptable manner.

Psychological Development. The development of appropriate feelings and emotional responses to events, people, and things falls under this head.

Moral Development. This includes understanding the universal concept of Morality; what is right and wrong.

Brain Health & Brain Development for Adolescents

Adolescence is an important time for brain development. The brain continues to develop and mature in the mid-to-late 20s. Changes in the areas of the brain responsible for social processes can entice teens towards peer relationships and social experiences, which, along with ongoing prefrontal cortex development, can potentially lead them to indulge in risky behavior. Since the teen brain is still developing, they may respond to stress differently than adults. This could increase their chances of developing stress-related mental illnesses, such as anxiety and depression. Recognizing this and practicing effective coping techniques can help teens deal with stress.

In adolescence, sleep hormone melatonin levels stay high later at night and drop later in the morning, which may explain why teens may stay up late and struggle with waking up early. Ongoing changes in the brain, along with physical, emotional, and social changes, can make teens more prone to experiencing mental health challenges. The fact that all these changes happen at one time may explain why many mental illnesses – such as schizophrenia, anxiety, depression, bipolar disorder, and eating disorders – appear during adolescence. Despite the stresses and challenges, most teens grow up as healthy adults. Some changes in the brain during this critical phase of development help support resilience and mental health over the long term.

Phases of Adolescence

Adolescence – Ages 10- 19 (WHO).

This is a transforming phase in the lives of children, moving them from being children to becoming adults. Adolescence is the phase where children start questioning their existence, religion, the world around them, laws, justice, and humanity. Family, as their first point of contact, plays a crucial role in shaping their concepts related to religion, humanity, and culture. During this phase, children internalize values by observing their parents' actions rather than following verbal instructions. For example, if a father smokes but tells his child not to, the child is likely to smoke because they see their father doing so. Similarly, if parents do not pray five times a day but ask their children to pray, the children are unlikely to follow their instructions unless the parents lead by example. Pre-teens and teenagers often experience strong or overwhelming emotions like shame and humiliation. They might know the words for these emotions but, still, have trouble recognizing and verbalizing them when they are upset. Also, because of brain development, pre-teens and teenagers do not always have the skills to express and manage emotions in a way that adults can.

Understanding teenagers in the Pakistani context can be quite challenging. Firstly, they are navigating a tricky phase, where they are neither considered children nor adults. In the part of the world where Pakistan is located, even after a child becomes an adult they still have to be obedient and listen to their parents. This can be frustrating, at times, to deal with; both for the parents and the adolescents.

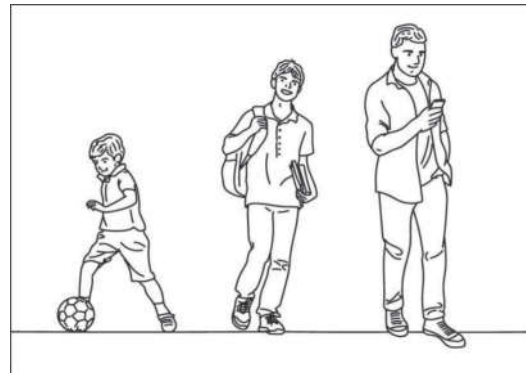
Secondly, they are dealing with heightened hormones, and peer pressure. Which is fueled by social media, and academic expectations. These factors often contribute to the mood swings and emotional

outbursts commonly associated with adolescence. It is essential to keep these challenges in mind while addressing issues and navigating difficult situations with teenagers. Some areas of concern, that the adolescents may struggle with, include:

- Depression
- Anxiety
- Bullying
- Sexual activity
- Drug and alcohol use
- Peer pressure
- Social media
- Violence

Pre-adolescence – middle childhood – 9-11 years.

In the pre-teen and teenage years, children go through many changes – physical, social, emotional and cognitive. During this time, children's bodies, emotions, and ideas about themselves develop and change at different speeds and times. These bodily changes are reflected in their clothing choices, the way they speak, and their perception of the world, all of which start to transform. For example, girls begin covering their heads and wearing dupattas, while boys stop wearing shorts.



Pre-adolescence or pre-teenage is also a time when children develop foundational skills for building healthy social relationships and start learning about roles, all of which will prepare them for becoming healthy adults. In addition to going through dramatic physical, social, emotional, and cognitive changes, they are also going through substantial changes in their life; they are trying to understand themselves and their social circle. They gradually develop into more independent individuals, who are influenced by what they see and hear at home, at school, and in the community. Hence, they begin to learn and understand things differently. They

- learn new skills like reading and writing, how to work with others, like being on a team,
- participate in different activities that teach them about customs and traditions,
- start appreciating differences; they make friends with children from all kinds of backgrounds and learn to understand and accept different points of view
- begin to understand that it is important to be kind and to do the right thing and practice doing these, over and over again
- show increasingly more interest in physical activities
- prefer not to be treated as a child
- begin to understand and adopt gender roles
- start forming social groups and friendships

Early adolescence – 12-14 years.

Early adolescence might be broadly considered to stretch between the ages of 12 and 14.

This is a period when physical changes generally commence; usually beginning with a growth spurt, followed by the development of the sex organs and secondary sexual characteristics. These external changes are often very obvious and can be a source of anxiety, as well as excitement or pride, for the individual whose body is undergoing the transformation. Puberty usually starts earlier for girls than for boys. In early adolescence, the brain also undergoes significant development, affecting emotions, physical abilities, and mental skills. The part of the brain responsible for decision-making starts developing during this time, with girls maturing earlier than boys.

During early adolescence, kids become more aware of their gender and may adjust their behavior to fit in. They might face issues like bullying and confusion about their identity. To a lesser or greater extent, they begin to:

- have an identity crisis
- be less concerned about threats or punishment
- get involved in increased risk-taking behaviors
- experience a rise in romantic interests
- feel increased boredom, disengagement, rudeness
- undergo a change in sleep patterns (sleep later)
- show a rebellious attitude

Late adolescence (15–19 years).

Late adolescence encompasses the latter part of the teenage years, broadly between the ages of 15 and 19 years. The major physical changes have usually occurred by now, although the body is still developing. However, the brain undergoes significant development, boosting analytical and reflective thinking. Moreover, while peer opinions are crucial initially, as adolescents become more self-assured, their reliance on peers diminishes. Also, in early to middle adolescence, risk-taking is common as individuals explore adult behaviors. However, in late adolescence, the ability to assess risks and make conscious decisions improves, leading to a decline in risky behaviors.



Late adolescence poses specific health risks;

for girls, this includes a higher likelihood of depression and eating disorders, often influenced by societal beauty standards. For boys in the Pakistani context, excessive drug and alcohol use can be a serious threat, as this can permanently damage the developing adolescent brain.

Late adolescence is a period when

- Puberty is completed
- Empathetic skills increase
- Decision-making capacity reaches adult levels; however, decisions tend to be short-term
- Ability to regulate emotions increases
- Peers influence is high
- Resistance to peer pressure reaches adult levels
- Susceptibility to depression is higher
- Influence of fatigue and stress is less
- Impulse control improves

Activity 2.1: Changes occurring during adolescence (15 minutes)

Objectives. The objective of this activity is to heighten the understanding of parents with regard to the changes that occur during adolescence and to enable them to talk to their children about these changes.

Resources.

- Flipchart and markers
- Box and slips of paper for puberty questions

Activity steps and instructions.

1. **Write** the definition of puberty on a flipchart and share these with the participants.
2. **Explain** to them that puberty is the time when a child moves through a series of significant, natural, and healthy changes. Many changes start happening in their bodies starting around the age of 10 to 12 years; and that the changes are not merely physical, occur in all spheres (mental, psychological, etc.). It can be difficult for children to understand why these changes are happening and whether they are normal.
3. **Ask them** whether they know what are the changes that the girls and boys experience during puberty?
4. **Brainstorm** with the group some of the changes happening in the body.
5. **Divide** the participants into two groups: a girls group and a boys group.
6. **Ask** each group to discuss what changes might be happening to a boy/ girl as they get older.
[girls: breasts and hips grow, start menstruation, skin becomes oily/breaks out, get taller, may gain weight, hair grows around genitals and armpits, sweat more, and body odor changes]
[boys: voice changes, grow taller, have wet dreams, skin becomes oily/breaks out, get taller, hair grows around genitals and armpits, sweat more, and body odor changes, voice changes, gains muscle] This usually happens around 10-11 years of age for girls and around 11-12 years for boys. But it is normal for the start of puberty to range from 8-13 years in girls and 9-14 years in boys.
7. **Ask** the participants:
 - Can you recall any changes in mood and feelings when you or your children were

growing up? [it is normal to feel sudden changes of mood, feel frustrated, angry, or sad more than usual; may also have increasing feelings of attraction and embarrassment; it is also normal to want more independence].

- Do you see changes in sleep patterns and energy levels? [need more sleep, and want to sleep later in the morning]
- Do you see changes in interests or in important relationships? [increasing importance of friends and peers – both same sex and opposite sex].
- Do you see changes in motor functions? [feels clumsy – trips and falls, drops things, runs into things]

Learning outcomes. At the end of the session the parents will be more informed about the biological, social, and psychological changes that occur during puberty, as this is the time when the bodies of boys and girls change. Parents can help their child by being well-informed; for example, by attending informative sessions – like the one they are attending right now, providing reassurance, and by role-modelling body acceptance and a healthy lifestyle.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Tell the participants that parents need to do the following to help their children during the transformative period in their life:

- a. Show affection to your child.
- b. Praise children for their efforts in completing tasks.
- c. Do not judge them harshly, as this can close down communication.
- d. Use “I” statements, for example, “I feel sad because you broke my trust,” instead of saying, “You are bad because you lied to me”.
- e. Teach children about respecting others. More importantly, teach them about good touch and bad touch. Teach them about creating and maintaining healthy boundaries.
- f. Help your children to set their own achievable goals; this will help them learn to take pride and rely less on approval or reward from others.
- g. Help your child learn patience, by letting others go first or by finishing a task before going out to play.

- h. Encourage them to express their opinions. Even if you do not agree with them, make them feel heard, and genuinely consider their opinion.
- i. Carve out time and schedule for fun things as a family, such as playing games, reading, and going to events in your community.
- j. Get involved with your child's school. Meet the teachers and staff to find out how your child is doing and to understand his or her learning tasks.
- k. Schedule weekly, or as time permits, reading time with your child. As your child learns to read, take turns reading to each other.
- l. Use positive discipline to guide and protect your child

Personal Hygiene and Grooming in Middle Childhood

Teach children to care about the way they look and smell. Encourage them to follow the tips given below, as these will help to increase their self-esteem.

- Shower daily, as sweat glands under the arms and around the genitals begin to secrete sweat, which can cause body odor.
- Use deodorants or antiperspirants, if possible.
- Change underclothes daily.
- Keep shoes clean, by brushing, polishing, or washing them.
- Wash their hair regularly.
- Brush their teeth twice a day

Talking to Adolescents about Puberty

Discussions on and around menstruation are often considered a cultural taboo in many parts of Pakistan. Often, individuals avoid discussing menstruation and related health and hygiene concerns. Whatever sex health education is available, it is often influenced by social and cultural stigmas. In the National Curriculum Framework of Pakistan, sexual health or menstruation health management is non-existent. The only health education mentioned in the National Educational Policy is “Physical Education, Health, and Sports in Education.” Girls in Pakistan usually learn about menstruation from their mothers or close female relatives.

A study of puberty and health-related concerns among adolescents in Karachi revealed several misconceptions around menstruation; the majority (98%) of the participants stated receiving the information from their mothers, who told them to avoid bathing (70%), praying or preaching (90%), carrying heavy weight (89%), and eating eggs, beef, and fish during menstruation. Moreover, even today, sanitary pads in Pakistan are sold in black plastic bags, and no one utters the words “period or pad” out loud. Girls pretend to pray during their “*off*” days, as they do not want the male members of the family to know about their periods.

A girl can start her period any time between the ages of 8 and 15. While timelines can vary, most girls get their first period within 2 – 3 years after the development of their breast buds. It is not unusual for breast growth to start on one side before the other. It is also common for breast buds to be somewhat tender or sore. Uneven breast growth and soreness are both totally normal and usually improve with

time. If a girl has not had her first period by the age of 15, or if it has been more than two to three years since breast growth started, it is strongly recommended that a doctor be consulted.

Adolescence is a transitional period between childhood and adulthood, which requires special attention and protection. This is a time when the brain undergoes substantial development, which affects emotional skills, and physical and mental abilities. Seek help if you notice any signs of depression or anxiety in your child. Moreover, puberty is the time in life when a boy or girl becomes sexually mature. It is a process that usually happens between the age of 10 and 14 for girls, and 12 and 16 for boys. It causes physical changes, and affects boys and girls differently. Keeping clean is an important part of staying healthy.

Sexual and Reproductive Health

Sexual interest develops in this phase. It is a process that usually happens between ages 10 and 14 for girls and ages 12 and 16 for boys. It causes physical changes, and affects boys and girls differently. Often, parents feel uneasy in discussing sexual and reproductive health with their children. Others use myths and scare tactics to discourage their children from early sexual experiences.

In the Pakistani context, providing education regarding puberty and sex is culturally discouraged. Traditionally, there is little conversation about puberty. Only 34 percent of the adolescents know about puberty before they experience it. The majority of the boys rely on their friends or fathers to obtain information about puberty, and girls on their mothers.

In girls, the first sign of puberty is usually breast development. Then hair grows in the pubic area and armpits. Menstruation (or a period) usually happens last. While in Boys, puberty usually begins with the testicles and penis getting bigger. Then hair grows in the pubic area and armpits. The muscles grow, the voice deepens, and facial hair develops as puberty continues. Both boys and girls may get acne. They also usually have a growth spurt (a rapid increase in height) that lasts for about two or three years. This brings them closer to their adult height, which they reach after puberty.

Parents often lack knowledge about:

- Anatomy
- Physiology
- Menstruation
- Puberty
- Wet dreams

- Masturbation
- Conception
- Contraception
- Other reproductive health issues

Factors contributing to the parents' anxiety could be:

- Cultural taboos
- Traditional beliefs, values, attitudes
- Fears and misinformation
- Fear that too much information without correct education could lead to experimentation

Most parents need assurance. Parent educators or facilitators, you can help them gain self-confidence by highlighting that:

- Nobody can be a perfect parent at all times.
- Parents strive to be the best parents with the experience, knowledge and tools they have.
- It is inhuman to expect perfection all the time.
- It is all right to be a little nervous or embarrassed around sexual topics in conversation

Activity 2.2: Changes during Puberty (15 minutes)

Objectives. By the end of the session, participants will:

- Gain a basic understanding of the physiological changes that happen in girls and boys during puberty
- Understand that puberty is a normal part of growing up, and something that everyone goes through, so it should not be a cause for shame or embarrassment

Resources.

- Flipchart and markers
- Box and slips of paper for puberty questions

Activity steps and instructions.

1. **Break up** the group into teams of two. Give each group a flipchart, paper, and a marker.
2. **Explain** that each team should draw the outline of either a girl or a boy. Once the outline is drawn, they should draw or write down the changes they think are happening to different parts of the body. Keep the brainstorming open, but if they have trouble understanding the directions, give a couple of examples, such as:
 - The head: Thoughts are changing – want to spend less time with family, more with friends
 - The underarms: Hair growing
 - The genitals: Period starts for girls, wet dreams for boys, sexual feelings for both

After 10 to 15 minutes, ask two teams to share what they have drawn. Ask the other groups who did not present if they have anything to add.

3. **Ask** participants how it felt to do this activity – what emotions or thoughts went through their minds?
4. **Explain:** The changes that we just discussed are completely normal.
5. **Distribute** the body changes handout,
6. **Ask** the participants:
 - What are some changes that are common in girls and boys?
 - What are some that are just for girls/just for boys?
 - How do you feel after today's session?

- What are some of the changes, discussed today, that were surprising or new information?
7. **Explain** that even when adolescents in a group are all close in age, some of them may look very different from others. This is because even though changes are common for everyone, they happen at different paces. Even if the changes and experiences during puberty are common, they do not always occur at the same pace, because everyone's body is special and unique. Hence, their adolescents may have different feelings and different levels of anxiety. Emphasize the importance of parental assurance to foster a sense of love and belonging.

Learning outcomes. This activity will help parents to understand their teens better. After this activity the hope is that they will be able to empathize with their teens more as they now have been educated of the physical changes occurring as their children are growing up.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Tell the parents that following the tips given below can be helpful.

- 1- Demonstrate value, respect, acceptance, and trust in their adolescent children.
- 2- Model sexually healthy attitudes in their own relationships.
- 3- Maintain a non-punitive stance toward sexuality.
- 4- Be more knowledgeable about sexuality.
- 5- Discuss sexuality with their children.
- 6- Provide information on sexuality to their children.
- 7- Seek appropriate guidance and information, as and when needed.
- 8- Try to understand their children's point of view.
- 9- Help their children gain an understanding of their values.
- 10- Set and maintain expectations for activities outside of school.
- 11- Stay actively involved in their children's life.
- 12- Ask questions about friends.
- 13- Provide a supportive and safe environment for their children.
- 14- Offer to assist adolescents in accessing health care services.

15- Help their children plan their future.

Guide parents on how to talk to and behave with your child. Here are some things that they can do.

Stay calm. It is important that you listen to what your child is sharing with you in order to respond, instead of reacting. Teens want to be heard and respected just like anyone else, and parents should be prepared to hear things that they may not agree with or are not comfortable hearing.

Talk about what being a friend means. Ask your children questions about what makes a good friend. Also ask if your child feels as if he or she can trust a new person; someone they have just met and would want to be with. Ask your teen why this particular person has impressed or influenced them. Encourage your teens to be themselves and to find peers who accept them for who they are.

Get to know your child's friends. Invite your children's friends to your house, to an outside event, or for a meal. This will provide you an opportunity to see what kinds of children they are interacting with and the influence that their friends may be having on them. It will also help if parents connect with their children at their level. Showing your child that you are interested and want to invest in their life and friendships may encourage them to have more honest communication with you.

Model saying "no". Show your child that it is okay to say no to something you do not want to do. Practice saying no with your child and equip your child with the skills s/he will need when the time comes. Teach them to say no to the "request" not to the "person".

Source Video Link

This video can be played after or during the session:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CM6GHNDInWQ>

Psycho-Social Challenges in Adolescents

In Pakistan, adolescents often face numerous psycho-social challenges that are rooted in socio-economic disparities, cultural norms, and gender inequality. The inadequate mental health support systems exacerbate their wellbeing. Parents must be aware of the challenges being faced by the adolescents. These challenges can range from mental health issues, like depression and anxiety, to pressures related to academic performance and social expectations. These challenges often go unnoticed due to lack of awareness and resources. If timely preventive measures are not taken, these issues can severely impact adolescents' mental and emotional well-being, potentially leading to long-term consequences such as poor academic performance, substance abuse, or even self-harm. Many adolescents encounter mental health issues, such as depression, anxiety, and stress.

Proactive parental involvement, open communication, and seeking professional help when needed are essential strategies to mitigate these risks and for providing support to adolescents through this critical developmental stage. By being vigilant and responsive to their children's needs, parents can help ensure that adolescents navigate these challenges successfully and develop into well-adjusted adults.

A positive support system, consisting of family, friends, and community, is also very crucial. Parents, in particular, can play a crucial role in providing this. Through effective communication, empathy, and by providing consistent emotional support, parents can protect adolescents and prepare them to deal with these challenges effectively. When parents show interest in adolescents' lives, and provide support and guidance for their emotional and psychological needs, they can help lessen the adverse effects of stress and anxiety. Additionally, parents who encourage involvement in community and religious activities can further strengthen the adolescents' support system, promoting a sense of connectedness and security.

Depression.

Pakistan has a fast-growing, young, and increasingly informed population. However, mental health literacy, treatments, and care in Pakistan do not meet the population's mental health needs. The stigma surrounding mental illness across cultures, due to collectivism and sociocultural-religious/spiritual beliefs and values, is reported to be the cause. Pakistan has a collectivistic culture, where the roles of family and relationships are emphasized when making decisions.

Epidemiological studies have shown that the onset of depression peaks during adolescence. Adolescent depression can affect normal growth, cause serious educational challenges, and damage social relationships with peers and families. Some of the contributing factors depression are:

- Peer and familial pressure
- Academic stress
- Changing hormone levels
- Body image concern

Identifying factors that depict depression and those that are a normal part of growing up can help parents address issues at an early stage. Some of these factors are presented in the table below.

DEPRESSION	NORMAL SADNESS
Feels isolated	Remain Hopeful
Excessive Past guilt and regrets	Enjoy happy moments
Sense of hopelessness	Maintain self-worth
Constant Sadness	Maintain connection
Loss of interest in activities	Remain capacity for pleasure
Suicidal thoughts/behavior	Maintain will to live

Signs and symptoms of potential depression among youth. Left untreated, depression can lead to self-harm. Therefore, identifying depression at an early stage is important. Signs of depression are usually diagnosed only by a professional. They include:

- Not taking interest in activities which were pleasurable for them
- Being sad and irritable
- Eating less or more
- Lethargic
- Having difficulty in concentration
- Feeling guilty, worthless, and hopeless
- Sleeping less or more
- Complaining boredom
- Suicidal ideation
- Not socializing
- Poor academic performance

Anxiety. Anxiety can be both helpful and harmful. Feeling anxious during exams serve as motivation and encourage adolescents to study for the exam. However, if anxiety is persistent and prolonged and is creating dysfunctionality, then it is harmful and must be treated by a professional.

The five types of anxiety disorders, as stated in DSM IV, include:

Generalized anxiety disorder. Signs include extreme worry about a variety of events – past, present, or future – that occur most days, for periods of six months or longer. Worries are about past conversations or behaviors, upcoming events, family problems, competence in sports, school events, etc. Such individuals have difficulty in controlling extreme amounts of worry, and the anxiety interferes with their daily life

Panic disorder. Signs include recurrent panic attacks and persistent anxiety that can lead to physical or psychological harm. Feelings of intense fear and unease, including physical symptoms and fearful thoughts, are obvious. Such individuals avoid going out and engaging in activities, out of fear that an attack may occur.

Separation anxiety. Signs include unwillingness to separate from major attachment figures, such as care-givers or home. These signs are mostly seen in children but can be experienced by adolescents.

Social Phobia. Signs include intense fear of embarrassment or humiliation in social situations. This may lead to shyness or fear and avoidance in attending parties, speaking with persons of authority, speaking in public, etc.

Specific Phobia. Signs include intense, irrational fear of specific things and situations. Exposure to the feared object or situation leads to extreme distress.

Activity 2.3: Giving Priority to Adolescents' Mental Health (20 minutes)

Objectives. The purpose of this activity is to highlight the importance of mental health awareness and how parents can become a support for their children.

Resources.

- Flashcards
- Markers

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Ask the participants what they think are the factors contributing to mental health issues in teens (e.g., academic pressure, social media, peer pressure). Facilitate an open discussion where parents can share their thoughts, experiences, and concerns about teen mental health.
2. Encourage parents to ask questions and seek clarification on any aspects of depression and anxiety.
3. Conduct a Role-playing activity (10 minutes):
 - Divide parents into small groups and ask them to share scenarios among themselves where the mental wellbeing of their teens was compromised.
 - Ask each group to select one scenario from those shared and prepare a role play to depict it.
 - Call out each group to act out the scenario and share some effective ways in which parents can support the teenager in the given situation.
 - Encourage creativity and problem-solving among the groups.

Learning outcomes. After the activity, the parents will gain a better understanding about depression and anxiety in teenagers, including common signs and symptoms, contributing factors, and the impact on adolescent well-being.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents.

Parents need to understand the importance of the following factors and use them to help their teenagers:

- Recognizing Signs
- Understanding Triggers
- Emotional Awareness
- Communication
- Self-Care
- Healthy Outlets
- Time Management
- Coping Strategies

This video shall be played after or during the session:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=CM6GHNDInWQ>

Peer Pressure

Even as preschoolers, children have peer pressure. They imitate their peers and try to be like them at a very young age. The influence of peer pressure increases during pre-teens; and its effects are even more powerful on teenagers. As the children grow older, they become more concerned about others' opinions, and may face both positive and negative peer pressures, like trying new activities or engaging in risky behaviors. It is important for parents to navigate these challenges by discussing peer pressure with their children and providing strategies for handling it during the pre-teen and teenage years. Educating and supporting children to recognize teenage peer pressure, when it helps and when it hinders them, and how they can develop their own individuality, is vital for parents.



Player Unknown's Battleground (PUBG)

One strong influence of peer pressure is related to internet gaming, which has gained popularity around the world, including in Pakistan. PUBG is one of Pakistan's most played online games. Pakistani parents and policymakers are concerned about the potential harm that the popularity of PUBG may have on children's mental and physical health. One study has concluded a strong link between PUBG and peer influence.

Activity 2.4: Dealing with Stressed Adolescents Undergoing Peer Pressure

Objectives. The aim of this activity is to encourage parents to contemplate the challenges their children encounter when dealing with peer pressure and to explore ways in which they can provide support during this difficult phase.

Resources.

- Flip chart and markers
- Paper

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Divide the participants in two groups.
2. Give each group one of the following scenarios and ask them to reflect upon it.

Scenario 1: Ali, a 15-year-old boy moves to the city with his parents, for better quality education. He comes home from school looking distressed. When questioned, he reluctantly admits to his parents that his classmates have been pressuring him to skip school and join them in hanging out at a local café. Despite knowing the importance of attending classes, Ali feels torn between the desire to fit in with his friends and the expectations of his parents to prioritize his education.

Scenario 2: Sana, a 17-year-old girl, is constantly comparing herself with her peers on the social media. She notices that many of her friends have started wearing makeup and dressing in trendy outfits. Feeling the pressure to conform to these standards of beauty, Sana expresses her desire to her parents to buy her expensive makeup products and designer clothes. She fears being negatively judged by her peers, if she does not keep up with the latest fashion trends.

3. Ask the participants to discuss the scenarios in their groups and also how they would help their child in dealing with such a situation.
4. Next, ask each group to share their ideas and their challenges as parents with all the participants.
5. Invite an open discussion on each scenario.

Learning outcomes: After the activity the parents can recognize the influence of peer pressure on their children's behavior, and support them in making decisions that align with their values and goals. They can engage in open communication, offer guidance, and help their children develop the confidence to resist negative peer influences.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Share the following strategies that parents can share with their children and ask them to consider these when pressurized by friends.

Pay attention to your emotions and gut feelings. If you feel that something is not right, chances are, it is not. Pay attention to your feelings and intuition. The more in-tune you are with your emotions, the better you will be at identifying them, staying calm in stressful situations, and remaining in control.

Find a friend who also says no. It can be hard to be the only person saying no. Find a friend who is also willing to say no to skipping class or smoking a cigarette, and spend time with this friend, doing something you both enjoy. There is strength in numbers, and you may find that more people may be joining you than going out for a smoke.

Talk to someone you trust. If you continue to feel pressured, talk to a teacher, counselor, parent, or friend about the situation. You will find it is helpful to talk through your emotions with someone you trust and on whom you can rely. These people can help you practice saying no, teach you how to say no in a different way, or help you come up with alternative solutions to saying no.

Influence of the Social Media

More and more youth in Pakistan are using the social media today. In Pakistan, there were over 72.9 million active social media users, as of early 2023, or roughly 31.5% of the total population was using it. Among the most widely used platforms are Facebook, Instagram, TikTok, and YouTube. There are 16.51 million users over the age of 18, with over 12.95 million users on Instagram, around 16.51 million users on TikTok, and YouTube ads reaching 82.1 percent of all internet users. Moreover, with 46.44 million users in Pakistan, Facebook is still quite popular.

Pakistani youth, are heavy internet users, especially school and college going students. A significant proportion of student's report spending more than five hours a day on the internet, with the majority utilizing the social media for relationship building and entertainment purposes.

The social media offers both benefits and drawbacks to students in Pakistan. Platforms like Facebook, WhatsApp, and Instagram have significantly aided students in their academic endeavors, facilitating easier and faster learning. These platforms enable students to collaborate on assignments, gather data, and access a wide range of educational resources. But their drawbacks, particularly in using the social media excessively, as this may result in distractions, thereby breaking into students' time for concentrated study and possibly harming their academic achievements. Moreover, students may experience stress and anxiety due to the spread of misleading information and a desire to follow specific online personalities. Hence, while social media can be an effective teaching/ learning tool, it is crucial that students utilize it responsibly and balance their online activity with other beneficial activities.

Furthermore, as a result of the considerable time that they spend online, the youth in contemporary Pakistan are getting detached from their families and friends. This has implications for the cultural values of the Pakistani society. However, that having been said, it cannot be denied that the social media is also a good source for remaining in touch with family members.

The positives of the Social Media

Education. Some of the positive aspects of the social media are as follows:

- Teachers are able to easily collaborate and communicate with students and one another.
- Students have easy, free access to resources online to help them learn.
- Students use social networking to discuss educational topics and to talk about school

assignments.

- Both teachers and students are able to access various sites and tools for educational purposes.

Awareness/being informed.

- Information spreads faster online than through any other media. More than 50% of individuals learn about breaking news on the social media.
- Social networking provides information on academic research to everyone; moreover, online access allows everyone access to previously unavailable resources.
- Social media sites can inform and empower individuals to change themselves and their communities.

Social benefits.

- Social media allows people to communicate with friends and increases online communication, which may strengthen relationships.
- People make new friends.

Affordable knowledge.

- Investing in research material may be tedious and unaffordable for some. But, now, thanks to the Internet, content websites, web encyclopedias, and dictionaries are available at the click of the button. Moreover, able as well as differently abled students can benefit from the sea of knowledge on the Internet.

Considering the increasing use of the Internet and the social media, it would be beneficial for parents and grandparents to educate themselves about navigating the technology, both that is used for the social media and for internet browsing, and its benefits and risks. In addition to other benefits, this knowledge will enable them to communicate more meaningfully with their teenagers. Family discussions are positive for teens and can result in less risky online behaviors. Many of the teens who said that their parents talked to them “a lot” reported:

- Greater concerns about online safety and sharing of personal information and photos, and increased understanding about limited sharing of information/pictures via the internet
- Lower incidence of public online profiles

- Lower incidence of talking or meeting people they only knew through online interactions
- Enhanced respect for privacy and empowerment

Negative Impacts of the Social Media

Social media has negatively impacted our young generation. Their personalities, mental health, time, education, and health are all compromised due to their social media addiction. The misuse of Tiktok, Instagram, etc., has also taken lives of some youth.

In Punjab, three youth lost their lives in motorcycle accident while making a TikTok clip

In 2024, in Gujrat, a girl accidentally shot her sister while making a TikTok video

In Karachi, 4 TickTokers lost their lives while shooting a TiKTok video

Monitoring trends, whether the teens are involved in or are affected by hacking, blackmailing, or cyberbullying is important. Parents can exercise parental control through tools available for tracking history and app activities, or by using software such as the Norton Family, to monitor their teens' activities. Additionally, setting boundaries, having open communication, and educating children about the risks must be made a priority by parents, for safe online usage.

Activity 2.5: Positive and Negative Effects of the Internet (20 minutes)

Objectives. By the end of this activity, parents will be able to identify the effects of the social media and its usage.

Resources.

- Flip chart and markers
- Papers and pens/ pencils

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Split participants into small groups.
2. Ask each group to list down the perceived benefits and risks of social media and internet usage for their children.
3. Request the groups to present their lists, one by one.
4. As the groups present, write the points on two flipcharts, one stating the benefits and the other the risks. Avoid repetitions on the list.
5. After all the groups have presented, have a whole group discussion.

Learning outcomes: By the end of the activity the parents will have some information regarding social media usage and parents' role in monitoring.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents.

Provide participants the following key points regarding monitoring children's/teens' activities on the social media:

- a. Regardless of how much your children resent it, you can only protect them by monitoring their online activities.
- b. Keep the computer in a busy area of your house, so that you can easily monitor its use, rather than allowing your child to use a laptop or tablet in his or her bedroom.
- c. Limit data access on your children's smartphones, if they have to use it to surf the web. Some wireless providers allow you to turn off text messaging services during certain hours.
- d. Set up filters on your child's computer. Tracking software can block inappropriate web content and help you check up on your child's online activities.

- e. Know who your child communicates with online. Go over your child's address book and instant messenger "buddy list" with them. Ask who each person is and how your child knows them.
- f. Teach children the importance of not sharing their passwords with anyone.
- g. Supervise your children's social media access.

Cyber Bullying

This type of bullying involves using the internet, technology, mobile phones, or electronic means to harass someone. For parents, it is important to identify the signs and symptoms of teens being bullied.

In the recent decade, there has been an increase in the use of the internet in Pakistan; with this, there has also been an increase in cyber bullying. A study has determined that cyber bullying affects the mental health of youth, resulting in negative academics' consequences, emotional disturbances, and effect on relationships. The results also showed a significant gender related difference; girls were more likely to be the sufferers and were more affected by cyberbullying, as compared to boys. Self-reported cyber bullying was examined among 328 Pakistani university students. Almost 90% of the participants were cyberbullied. However, no significant differences were found in terms of demographic characteristics.

Another study reported that six in ten children in Pakistan knew a lot or something about online bullying. Cyberbullying knows no boundaries and affects individuals across all age groups and backgrounds. Conventional bullying and cyberbullying are not only a problem in higher educational institutions in Pakistan; both forms are also found in primary and secondary schools. The majority of the victims who are subjected to online harassment do not label it as such and, consequently, they never report it.



Signs that your child is a victim of cyber bullying. If your child shows any or some of the following signs, chances are that s/he is a victim of cyber bullying:

- Being upset after using the Internet or receiving a text message
- Becoming secretive about his or her digital life
- Beginning to withdraw from family and friends
- Shying away from participating in group activities
- Avoiding school and group events

- Experiencing a decline in grade point average
- Refusing to do homework
- Showing drastic changes in mood, sleep, and appetite patterns
- Wanting to stop using the phone or computer
- Becoming nervous when new messages come in
- Engaging in self-destructive behavior

Signs that your child might be the bully. Watch out for the following signs, as these indicate that your child might be involved in bullying others:

- Encourages others to do the bullying
- Is very aggressive toward everyone
- Is being sent to the principal's office regularly
- Receives frequent detentions
- Starts acquiring new belongings or unexplained money
- Does not take responsibility for anything, including his or her actions
- Is very competitive and worried about his or her popularity

Parents' role in monitoring cyber bullying.

Tell the participants that all parents want to protect their children from the outside world. However, with the rapid advancement in current technology, sometimes, the outside world comes to them. If you feel your child is being cyber bullied, the best thing you can do is to sit down and offer your support and guidance towards finding a solution. Once you have identified the bully you can take action, along with your child, to stop the bullying. Assure your child it is not his or her fault.

Parents should not threaten to take away their child's electronic gadget or to cut their online time, as they may see this as punishment and be less willing to share future bullying situations with you.

Parents need to monitor everything that their child is doing on Facebook, for example, and open the door for active dialogue to occur. Only through communication will parents know what their child is experiencing or doing. Talk with your child about their experience. Studies show that having just one person providing a listening ear and support in bullying situations helps



children to be better able to handle it in a healthy way. Simultaneously, screen your children's friends, so as to minimize peer pressure and the negative influences of the social media, including bullying.

Cyber bullying is another growing trend among social media websites; it can have dangerous and potentially fatal effects. Through cyber bullying, someone is tormented, threatened, harassed, humiliated, embarrassed, or otherwise targeted by another person, by using the Internet, interactive and digital technologies, or mobile phones. Cyber bullying is similar to other types of bullying, except that it takes place online and through text messages sent on cell phones. Cyber bullies can be classmates, online acquaintances, and even anonymous users, but most often they do know their victims. With the increase in accessibility to electronic devices in today's society, cyber bullying has become a major issue across the world. However, remember that abuse is rarely a child's fault. Always believe your child!

Activity 2.6: Awareness Regarding Cyberbullying (10 minutes)

Objectives. The objective of this activity is to create awareness regarding cyber bullying and the impact it has on a child's mind. This activity will help parents to protect their children from cyber bullying.

Resources.

- Paper notes, with the scenario and the outcome written on them
- Chart paper and markers

Activity steps and instructions.

1. Read the following scenario. Ask the participants to listen carefully.

Kanza was a 13-year-old girl who grew up in Sialkot. She accidentally sent one of her photos to her classmate. The classmate sent her picture to other classmates for fun. One of the classmates used the Photoshop software and made the picture look vulgar by portraying her as undressed. This picture was forwarded to other students in the class group. And so, the image found its way to a lot of other students in her school and in other schools. The result was that her peers began taunting and bullying her peers at school, using insults such as “whore” and “slut”.

Kanza wrote in her journal: “People call me all sorts of vulgar names and talk behind my back; they use inappropriate words for me! I can't be a whore; secretly TONS of people hate me ...

The school authorities found out about the nude photo around the end of the school year and suspended Kanza for the first week of the second form, which started in August. When she returned to school, a counselor observed cuts on Kanza's legs and had her sign a “no-harm” contract, in which Kanza agreed to tell an adult if she felt inclined to hurt herself.

On September 12, 2009, Kanza wrote in her journal: “I am done for sure now. I can feel it in my stomach. I'm going to try and strangle myself. I hope it works”. The next day, Kanza hung herself in her bedroom.

2. Divide the students in groups and ask them to discuss the following questions in their groups:
 - a. What is taking place in this scenario?
 - b. How could this incident have been avoided?
 - c. Who is to blame for the outcome?

d. Did she show any signs of emotional trauma?

3. Once they have discussed, have a whole group discussion and ask the participants to share their views.

4. Next, ask them how else the social media could have been used to avoid this tragedy. Elicit responses from the participants and write some of these on the flip chart

5. Participants can also be asked to share their experiences and the role that parents can play in such situations.

Learning outcomes. At the end of this activity, parents will become more aware about cyber bullying and the impact it has on a child's mind. This will help parents in protecting their children from cyber bullying.

Notes for facilitators & follow-up actions by parents. Tell parents to share the tips given below with their children, to guide and protect them from being bullied.

1. Never say something about someone online that they would not say to that person face-to-face.
2. Be mindful about what you post or share as it can have detrimental consequences for them and for others.
3. Bullying others, online or in person, is never an appropriate behavior.
4. Comments and images posted on the internet can be long-lasting and have a global audience.
5. Keep the passwords to your online accounts private.
6. Create passwords that are a combination of letters and numbers and are difficult to guess.
7. Passwords should not be shared with friends, not even a best friend.
8. Handle strong emotions, such as anger, resentment, or jealousy, also expressions of love, in an appropriate manner. It is never appropriate to send a message or post a comment on the Internet when you are experiencing heightened emotions.
9. Be careful while sharing your pictures.